

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

Giving the Benefit of the Doubt

In late April, Amara found her Grace Gap.

It happened on a Tuesday morning, when she was walking from the gym to the cafeteria. She was taking the long way, because she had remembered halfway through gym that she had left her water bottle by the lockers, and she had run back for it, and now she was walking past the gym for a second time.

She saw the bench.

The bench was outside the gym. It was a long wooden bench, painted dark green, that had been there forever — since before any of the kids in Room 18 had even started school. The bench was where kids sat to wait when they had to leave class for something. It was also — and this was the thing — where kids who didn't make a team sat after tryouts. The basketball tryouts. The soccer tryouts. The cross country tryouts. The chorus tryouts. The school had a lot of tryouts, and not every kid made every team, and the kids who did not make it sat on the bench afterward, sometimes for a while, waiting for somebody to come pick them up.

Amara had been one of those kids in second grade. She had tried out for the school chorus, in the very last week of second grade, and had not made it. She had sat on the bench for almost forty minutes, waiting for her mother. Other kids had walked past. Some kids who had made the chorus had walked

past, laughing, on their way to a celebration. Nobody had stopped. Nobody had said hi. Nobody had said *I am sorry you didn't make it.*

She had sat there alone. She had cried a little. She had wiped her face before her mother got there.

She had never told anybody about that afternoon.

Today, walking past the bench, she saw a fifth-grader sitting on it. The fifth-grader was a boy she did not know by name. He had clearly just come from something — basketball tryouts, maybe. He had a duffel bag at his feet. He was sitting very still. He was not looking at his phone. He was just looking at the ground.

Amara knew that posture.

She thought about walking past. She thought, for a half-second, that maybe the boy wanted to be alone. Maybe stopping would be weird.

Then she remembered the lesson on the kindest possible reason. *What is the kindest possible reason for the way he is sitting? The kindest reason: he is having a hard day, and a small piece of kindness would help.*

Then she remembered her own bench afternoon.

She walked over. She did not sit down — she did not want to crowd him. She stopped a few feet away.

"Hi. I am Amara. I am in third grade."

He looked up.

"Hi," he said.

"Are you okay?"

He shrugged. "Did not make the team."

"Oh. I am sorry."

"Yeah."

"It happened to me last year. With chorus."

"Yeah?"

"Yeah. I sat on this exact bench. For a long time."

The boy almost smiled.

"It is not great," he said.

"No. It is not."

She stood there for a moment. She did not know what else to say. She was not going to give him a hug. She was not going to give him a speech. She was just — there.

Then she did one more thing.

"My name is Amara, and I am in Mr. Patel's class. If you ever want somebody to say hi to in the hallway who knows about not making chorus, I am that person. Just so you know."

The boy looked at her.

"Okay. Thanks."

She nodded. She walked to the cafeteria.

That was it. That was the whole thing.

Forty seconds, maybe. One sentence about chorus. One offer to say hi in the hallway.

But the boy, that night, would go home and tell his mother that a third-grader he did not know had stopped at the bench and said hi. His mother would say *that is so kind, sweetheart*. The boy would say, *yeah. It helped*.

That is the size of a Grace Gap fill.

Sometimes it is forty seconds long.

The next day, in Room 18, Amara raised her hand at the beginning of the SEL lesson.

"Yes, Amara?"

"Ms. Calloway. I think I found my Grace Gap."

"Tell me."

"The bench. Outside the gym. The bench where kids sit after tryouts when they didn't make it. Nobody ever talks to those kids. They just sit there."

Ms. Calloway did something she did not often do. She put her hand on her heart.

"Amara. That is exactly the kind of gap I was hoping somebody would find. Tell me what you want to do."

"I want to walk past the bench, every day, on the way to lunch, and just see whoever is sitting there. If somebody is on the bench, I will stop and say hi. Just hi. If they want to talk, we can talk. If they don't, I just go. The point is they are not invisible."

"Amara. That is your micro-moment. That is perfect."

Amara nodded.

"I have one more thing."

"Yes?"

"I want to make a sign. To put on the bench. The sign would say — I do not know exactly what it would say. Something like *if you are sitting here because you did not make a team, you are not invisible. You matter. Somebody made this bench warm for you. But shorter. And nicer.*"

Ms. Calloway smiled.

"Amara. The sign is a beautiful idea. Why don't you write a draft of the sign tonight. Bring it in. We can make it together. Or you can make it with your mom. Whatever you want."

Amara wrote the sign that night.

She wrote three drafts. The first one was too long. The second one was too short. The third one was right.

It said:

HEY YOU,

Sitting on this bench? Did you just try out for something and not make it?

That's hard. We know.

You are not invisible. Somebody noticed you.

If you want to talk to somebody – find a third-grader named Amara in Mr. Patel's class.

If you want to be alone – that is okay too.

Either way: you are not nothing for not making the team. You are everything you were yesterday. You are still you.

– The kids of Room 18

She brought it in the next day. The class read it together. Some kids suggested small changes. Theo suggested they put a small smiley face on the bottom, but small, not too cheesy. The kids agreed.

Mr. Patel got permission from the principal for the sign to be posted near the bench. He laminated it. He helped Amara hang it up that Friday afternoon.

It was a small laminated sign. It was on the wall near the bench. It was, in the larger world of the school, a tiny thing.

But it would, over the rest of the spring, be read by approximately eighty-two kids who sat on that bench after a tryout they did not make. Some of them would cry while reading it.

A few of them would find Amara in the hallway. One of them, a sixth-grader, would write Amara an anonymous thank-you note that she would keep in her journal for the rest of her life.

This is the size of one nine-year-old's grace, when it is given the chance to be small and consistent and named.

This is a Grace Gap, filled.

The bench is still there. The sign is still there. (It has been replaced twice, when the lamination got worn. The new versions are written in different kids' handwriting now. The bench has become a tradition of the school.)

Amara started it.

A bench outside a gym, in a school in a town in a country, became a place where kids who didn't make the team got to feel — for a minute, sometimes for a while — that somebody had seen them.

That is what grace looks like, in practice. That is what it looks like to fill a gap.